



STATUS REPORT

Lesotho: status report

Edition of 2026-08-25 · 64 systems and instruments tracked

Compiled 2026-08-25 by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository, from [outputs/reports/LS0/Ledger.csv](#) (64 systems and instruments, 0 of them **Not held**). Each section opens with its ledger; specific events are covered in the monthly updates. Figures are dated because most are time-varying.

SUMMARY OF POSITION · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS · GAPS TO FILL

Status values. *Implemented* — in operation or in force. *Piloting* — running with a limited user group or in a controlled environment. *In development* — build or drafting under way, not yet operating. *Planned* — announced or provided for, no build or draft on record. *Enacted* — an instrument passed into law; pair with a qualifying clause for its in-force date. *Under review* — a law or policy currently being reconsidered. *Discontinued* — closed or superseded. *Not held* — the base carries no reliable statement of status; these are the gaps to fill and are listed again at the end.

Summary of position

Lesotho's current position rests on a payments and social-protection layer that has been running for several years, and a policy layer signed in the middle of 2026 whose texts are not on file. The [LeSwitch](#) national switch clears instant payments, ATM withdrawals and card transactions at point of sale inside the country across four commercial banks, and the mobile wallets that sit on it now carry a [licensed retail investment product](#). The social registry holds data on [more than 90% of households](#). Against that, the framework governing personal data is a statute from 2011 whose supervisory commission [has never been appointed](#).

The three foundational policies — broadband infrastructure sharing, data management and artificial intelligence — were [signed on 12 June 2026](#), and the wiki holds the reported signings rather than the instruments, so what each requires, of whom and by when cannot be stated from the base.

The largest commitment on the record is Project Kobong, [approved on 31 July 2026](#): at least 1,200MW of pumped-storage hydropower paired with an AI data centre at Mokhotlong, on an agreement binding as to process but conditional on feasibility, financing, permitting and definitive agreements, with construction targeted for 2029. The maloti figure is the government's throughout; [Convalt Energy's own release](#) of 8 June 2026 confirms the agreement and the capacities and states no value.

An interim national CSIRT [began operating on 29 July 2026](#) while the two bills that would give it a statutory footing await National Assembly approval, and the National Cybersecurity Strategy the launch was described as implementing is not held here.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Broadband Infrastructure Sharing Policy	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Signed by the MICSTI minister, 2026-06-12
Data Management Policy	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Signed by the MICSTI minister, 2026-06-12
National AI Policy	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Signed by the MICSTI minister, 2026-06-12
National AI Strategy	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Drafting workshop opened in Maseru 2026-08-17
National Digital Policy 2024	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Issued in 2024
National Digital Transformation Strategy: Agenda 2030	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched in 2024

Legislation and regulation

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Cybercrime Bill	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Awaiting National Assembly approval, 2026-07-29
Cybersecurity Bill	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Awaiting National Assembly approval, 2026-07-29

Data protection

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Bilateral health agreement with the United States and its data-sharing instrument	IMPLEMENTED, TEXT WITHHELD ↗	Signed in December 2025, stated at US\$364m
Data Protection Act 2011	IMPLEMENTED ↗	In force since 2011
Data Protection Commission	PLANNED ↗	Provided for by the 2011 Act; no commissioner appointed as at 2026-03-23

Regional collaboration

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
50-in-5 DPI campaign membership	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Joined as the fourteenth member, May 2024
African Union Data Policy Framework domestication	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Readiness workshop convened by AUDA-NEPAD, 28-31 July 2025

Standards

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
LCA Quality of Service Rules (Legal Notice 41 of 2023)	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Legal Notice No. 41 of 2023 gazetted, in force 2023-04-21

Public debate and participation in policymaking

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Public digital services experience survey	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Opened 2026-08-09

Two instruments carry the framework: the National Digital Policy 2024 and the National Digital Transformation Strategy: Agenda 2030. Three more — broadband infrastructure sharing, data management and artificial intelligence — were signed in June 2026 and none of the texts is held; all three were already reported under development in the [2025/26 budget speech of 19 February 2025](#), more than a year before signature.

The [LCA Quality of Service Rules](#), gazetted 21 April 2023, set the one published, binding standard in this area, with minimum thresholds for voice, data, postal and courier licensees. The LCA's [Annual Report 2024/25](#) recorded 75% overall compliance across twelve general parameters for the year to 31 March 2025, missing on disconnection-complaint resolution time and mobile order-completion time; its [Q3 2025/26 drive-testing](#) in Maseru, November 2025, measured mean LTE download speeds of 2.88-2.95 Mbps against the Rules' 25 Mb/s target.

Personal data is governed by an Act in force since 2011. The Data Protection Commission it provides for was still unappointed as at March 2026, which is stated by [Cenfri](#) rather than by the government. No regulator is therefore in place to approve, audit or refuse a data flow.

Regional alignment is convened rather than completed. A four-day AUDA-NEPAD workshop on domesticating the African Union Data Policy Framework [ran in July 2025](#), and no readiness assessment, legislative review or resulting instrument from it is held. Lesotho joined the [50-in-5 campaign](#) as its fourteenth member in May 2024.

No government open-data portal is held. An [SBC4D/IREX capacity assessment](#) prepared for the Millennium Challenge Corporation and the Lesotho Millennium Development Agency, dated September 2021, found no active government open-data programme, a civil-society Lesotho Open Data Initiative launched in 2019, a ranking of 151st of 187 countries in Open Data Watch's 2020 Open Data Inventory, and no access-to-information legislation in force.

The one governance instrument that is known to exist and known to be withheld is the bilateral health agreement with the United States, [signed in December 2025 and stated at US\\$364m](#). A [FOIA complaint filed on 2 April 2026](#) records that the State Department briefly published a subset of the memoranda in March 2026 and then removed public access, and that the related data-sharing agreements have not been published; Lesotho is one of sixteen countries named.

Finance

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Domestic budget appropriation for digital transformation	IMPLEMENTED ↗	M381.1 million allocated to the ICT sector, delivered in the 2025/26 budget speech, 2025-02-19

MoUs and other agreements

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Development-partner support for the data blueprint	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Smart Africa, the African Union and the German Embassy named as supporters of the first workshop

A domestic budget line for digital transformation is on record for the first time. The [2025/26 budget speech](#), delivered 19 February 2025, allocated M381.1 million to the ICT sector and named a Government Security Operations Centre, a Government of Lesotho Enterprise Architecture and Interoperability Framework, a completed feasibility study for the Lesotho Metropolitan Fibre Distribution Network, 17 already-operational base tower stations and a 96km Roma-Thaba-Tseka fibre stretch under way.

Development-partner support for the National Data Value Creation Blueprint — Smart Africa, the African Union and the German Embassy — was named as supporting its [first workshop](#), with no programme document, terms of reference or amount published.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Econet Telecom Lesotho 5G network	IMPLEMENTED ↗	5G sites grown from 54 to 149 on 700MHz
Econet Wi-Fi Plus fixed-mobile convergence service	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched 2025-07-11
Lesotho Metropolitan Fibre Distribution Network (LEMOFI)	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Feasibility study completed, per the 2025/26 budget speech, 2025-02-19
Starlink operating licence	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Ten-year satellite internet licence granted by the LCA, 2025-04-14
Starlink satellite internet service	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched through T-Connect as exclusive reseller, 2025-06-30
Vodacom Lesotho mobile network	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Thirtieth-anniversary account of the network, 2026-06-17

Data Storage

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
National data-centre implementation roadmap	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Drafting workshop opened in Maseru 2026-08-17
Project Kobong hydropower and AI data centre	PLANNED ↗	Approved and launched at a ceremony hosted by the US Embassy, 2026-07-31

Technical Capacity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Mohale's Hoek government data centre	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Toured near-complete by the Communications Minister; power station awaited (~2018-07)

Cybersecurity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Government Chief Information Security Officer	IMPLEMENTED ↗	First appointment across government reported 2026-07-29
Interim national CSIRT (LesComCSIRT)	IMPLEMENTED, INTERIM ↗	Launched in Maseru 2026-07-29
National Cybersecurity Forum	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Inaugural meeting 2026-07-29
National Security Operations Centre	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Reported being stood up, 2026-07-29
National Cybersecurity Strategy	NOT HELD, SEARCHED 2026-08-10 — OXFORD/C3SA CYBERSECURITY CAPACITY MATURITY MODEL REVIEW RATED THE STRATEGY DIMENSION START-UP AND FOUND NO OFFICIAL NCS	Oxford/C3SA Cybersecurity Capacity Maturity Model review confirmed no official National Cybersecurity Strategy, 2023-03-31

The mobile market has two operators and a satellite entrant. Vodacom Lesotho reported [1.21m customers and 85% market share at its thirtieth anniversary in June 2026](#), on 422 base stations of which 101 are solar, with 4G reaching 96% of the population; a US\$40m upgrade was [announced in March 2026](#). Econet Telecom Lesotho's most recent

published network figure is [149 5G sites on 700MHz in June 2025](#), and nothing later is held. A separate fibre backbone, the Lesotho Metropolitan Fibre Distribution Network, had its feasibility study completed by the time of the [2025/26 budget speech of 19 February 2025](#), with no construction reported since.

Starlink holds a ten-year licence [granted on 14 April 2025](#) and has been retailing through T-Connect since June 2025. [The rights group Section 2 objected](#) that full foreign ownership departs from the local-participation terms attached to both mobile operators, and Vodacom's appeal for local shareholding has no recorded outcome.

The [Mohale's Hoek data centre was toured near-complete on 24 May 2018](#), a Tier III design built as 100km-separated backup to the Finance Ministry's Maseru data centre, left needing only its power station; no later source confirms completion or operational status. Project Kobong is the newer and far larger commitment: no rack, floor-area or power figure has been published for it either, and the project's own premise is that the electricity does not yet exist – about 72MW installed against about 209MW of domestic demand, with [438 of the 970 GWh consumed in 2024 imported](#).

The cybersecurity institutions are new and, in the case of the response team, explicitly interim. Alongside the CSIRT and the National Cybersecurity Forum, the ministry reports a first Chief Information Security Officer appointed across government and a Security Operations Centre being stood up, for which no host, operator or date is [published](#); the same centre was first budgeted, as a Government Security Operations Centre, in the [2025/26 budget speech](#) more than a year earlier. The minister dates the threat they answer to an attack on the government financial system in June 2023 that forced a shutdown, an attack on the Central Bank roughly six months later that stopped bank transfers, and attacks on the Judiciary's electronic systems. An [Oxford/C3SA capacity review](#) found the strategy the launch invoked did not officially exist as of 31 March 2023.

DPI

Data Exchange

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Government of Lesotho Enterprise Architecture and Interoperability Framework	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Under development, per the 2025/26 budget speech, 2025-02-19
X-Road government interoperability platform	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Presented at the MICSTI-NUL review of DPI progress, 2026-02-20

Digital Identity and CRVS

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Digital birth registration under Ntlafatsa Bana	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched with the European Union and UNICEF, 2025-04-02
Digital service-ID pilot	PILOTING ↗	Pilot programme set to begin 2026-04-02, about 10,000 participants, announced 2026-03-25
MOSIP-based integrated national digital ID	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	2026 work plan signed by MICSTI and UNICEF, 2026-03-03
National Identification System	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Documented in the World Bank GovTech case study, 2022

Digital Payments and Fintech

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
EcoCash mobile money	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Platform migration completed October 2024
LeSwitch national payment switch	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Card transactions at point of sale localised from 2025-05-11
M-Pesa Lesotho (VCL Financial Services)	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Mobile money spun off into VCL Financial Services, 2026-03-13

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Renminbi settlement access through CIPS	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Standard Bank extended CIPS access beyond South Africa to five markets including Lesotho
Revenue Services Lesotho tax e-payment integration	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched with Standard Lesotho Bank, 2026-02-11
Tsetela wallet investment service	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched in Maseru 2026-07-22

Registries

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
NISSA social registry	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Child-centred redesign piloted in Mafeteng District

Sectoral management information systems

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Decision Support System for planning and budgeting	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Presented at the MICSTI-NUL review of DPI progress, 2026-02-20
Foundational Literacy and Numeracy Dashboard	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	UNICEF and Global Partnership for Education support announced, 2026-07-23
MISSA social-assistance management information system	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Request for proposals closed 12 August 2024
National monitoring and evaluation reporting capacity	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Consultancy advertised 2026-08-16

Other GovTech and e-Gov

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
E-Parliament system	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Completion reported in the 2025/26 budget speech, 2025-02-19
eGovernment Infrastructure Project Phase II	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Digital Outreach Studio launched under the project, 2026-06-12
National Data Value Creation Blueprint	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	First national stakeholder consultative workshop, 14-15 July 2026
Separate government ICT agency	PLANNED ↗	Announced as a plan to move ICT services out of the civil service, 2026-07-29

Payments are the deepest part of the base. LeSwitch has localised instant transfers, ATM transactions and, since May 2025, card transactions at point of sale; e-commerce and retail were named as the next stage and nothing since is held. On top of it, Vodacom's mobile money was [reconstituted as VCL Financial Services in March 2026](#) and runs 14,000 agents, Econet's EcoCash has been on a [migrated platform since October 2024](#), and Tsetela opened investment from M50 for individual customers and M300 for group-savings customers over USSD. Two narrower rails were added in 2026: [tax e-payment](#) for company tax, PAYE, VAT and customs duties, and [renminbi settlement through CIPS](#).

Identity is the layer with the widest gap between activity and delivery. The National Identification System operates, but the most recent account of it held here is a [World Bank case study from 2022](#), so no current coverage or enrolment figure can be given. The replacement is a [MOSIP-based integrated national digital ID](#) under a 2026 work plan with UNICEF, covering passport and identity-card renewal, biometric registration and proof-of-life verification. A separate [digital service-ID pilot](#) of about 10,000 participants was announced on 25 March 2026 to begin 2 April 2026, tying registration to an existing national identity document, a registered SIM card and biometric registration; no vendor, legal basis or evaluation criteria has been stated. [Digital birth registration](#) runs under the Ntlafatsa Bana programme.

The interoperability and analytics layers are at presentation stage. X-Road and a Decision Support System were both [shown as work in progress in February 2026](#) with no go-live date, alongside a Government of Lesotho Enterprise Architecture and Interoperability Framework named as under development in the [2025/26 budget speech](#), aimed at government efficiency and avoiding fragmented ICT procurement. The [NISSA](#) registry is the exception – it is in operation and is being redesigned around children's data – while its management information system, MISSA, has not moved past a [request for proposals that closed in August 2024](#). The [eGovernment Infrastructure Project Phase II](#), an African Development Bank commitment of US\$13.95m made in 2019 and due to end in 2026, is the standing financing behind this layer; the same budget speech reported an E-Parliament system already completed, modernising legislative processes.

Sub-national government has one system on record: Maseru City Council's [Construction Permit Automation System](#), built by Computer Business Solutions (Lesotho) with Web Masters Kenya under World Bank funding, live at mcc-cp.org.ls from application through to digital permit issue.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Maseru City Council Construction Permit Automation System	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Project page dated 2025-04-02; live at mcc-cp.org.ls

Rural digital data capture

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
T-Connect Impact school and clinic connectivity	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched at Soofia International School, Butha-Buthe, 2026-01-17

Technology

AI

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
National AI Academy	PLANNED ↗	Named in the UNDP-Econet memorandum signed 2026-07-28

ICT Industry

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Private-sector cloud and cybersecurity capacity	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Executive workshop hosted in Maseru by DNS Technologies and CBS, 2026-05-30

Innovation ecosystem

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
UNDP-Econet memorandum of understanding	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Signed at the Mpilo Boutique Hotel, Maseru, 2026-07-28

The artificial-intelligence position is an approved data-centre project, a signed policy whose text is not held, and one institutional commitment. A [National AI Academy](#) is proposed in the memorandum Econet Telecom Lesotho and UNDP signed on 28 July 2026, with no timetable, governance structure, curriculum or host institution named; the same memorandum renews a partnership first signed in 2020 and amended in 2022, and states no amount, term or deliverable.

Two external relationships shape the sector. The [Lesotho–India memorandum](#) of July 2025 named digital ID, a unified payment environment and once-only information exchange as the year's priorities, and no deliverable under it is on record. On the American side, the [US Embassy states](#) that it has facilitated US\$7.3bn of commercial partnerships in Lesotho over eighteen months, of which Kobong is the largest — the embassy's own figure, attributed as such.

Domestic technology capacity outside the two operators appears once, as an [executive workshop in Maseru](#) on ransomware, cloud security and data sovereignty.

Capacity

Training and skills

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
AI Skills Development Programme	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched with the US Embassy under the Sebatatso initiative, 2026-06-17
Government digital-literacy training in all ten districts	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Reported running across all ten districts, 2026-07-29
Vodacom and AWS digital-skills training	PLANNED ↗	Pledged at the Vodacom group chief executive's visit, 2025-08-25

Research institutions

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Government and National University of Lesotho DPI collaboration	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Joint review of DPI progress with the Mathematics and Computer Science department, 2026-02-20

Inclusion

The base holds no inclusion rows for Lesotho. A thin evidence base is a finding, not a gap in this document.

The government's own measure of the access problem is coverage against use: [100% broadband coverage and about 50% regular internet use](#), which MICSTI attributed to affordability at the UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance in July 2026. Rural reach is being extended by satellite rather than by terrestrial network: [community hotspots](#) handed over through principal chiefs, and [school and clinic connectivity](#) from January 2026.

Training is thin and externally supplied. The [AI Skills Development Programme](#) with the US Embassy is the one programme on record delivering, digital-literacy training is reported across all ten districts with no participant numbers published, and a digital-skills pledge made with AWS in August 2025 has nothing recorded against it since.

As South African remittance and banking rules tightened, [migrant workers moved from banks to fintechs](#). No domestic budget appropriation for digital transformation is held, so what the state itself spends cannot be stated.

Data

Open data

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
National open data portal	NOT HELD, SEARCHED 2026-08-10 — SBC4D/IREX CAPACITY ASSESSMENT FOUND NO ACTIVE GOVERNMENT OPEN-DATA PROGRAMME AND NO ACCESS-TO-INFORMATION LEGISLATION IN FORCE	SBC4D/IREX capacity assessment for MCC/LMDA found no government open-data activity, September 2021

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
US commercial diplomacy in the digital and energy sectors	IMPLEMENTED ↗	US Embassy states US\$7.3bn of commercial partnerships facilitated over eighteen months

India activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Lesotho-India digital public infrastructure memorandum	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Signed during the Indian minister of state's visit to Maseru, 2025-07-29

Gaps to fill

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
National Cybersecurity Strategy	The text of the strategy the minister invoked at the LesComCSIRT launch, or an official statement of its adoption date, version and targets. The 2022 Cybersecurity Capacity Maturity Model review states Lesotho had no official national strategy.	2026-08-10
National open data portal	A government open-data portal or published open-data policy for Lesotho, or an official statement that none exists.	2026-08-10

Two absences remain. The National Cybersecurity Strategy is invoked in official statements but has no published text; an [Oxford/C3SA capacity review](#) rated its strategy dimension Start-up and found no official strategy existed as of 31 March 2023, and nothing later on record supersedes that finding. No National open data portal is held either; an [SBC4D/IREX capacity assessment](#) found no active government open-data programme as of September 2021, and nothing later on record supersedes that finding.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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